



ALL WRAPPED UP

Jules Védrines, wearing a leather flying suit and large scarf, is surrounded by a small crowd of officials and reporters after winning the second leg of the 1911 Paris–Madrid race in San Sebastian, Spain. Védrines was one of the top racing pilots of the period and went on to fly for the French army in World War I.

was a worthy victor at an average speed of 61mph (98kph). The excitement of the Gordon Bennett race was eclipsed, however, by a race from Belmont Park around the Statue of Liberty and back. Given the state of aviation safety, it's beyond belief that such an event, flown mostly over a densely populated area, could have been permitted. Fortunately, it passed without mishap, but it ended in dispute and recrimination. Grahame-White felt that he had won the race since American pilot

John B. Moisant, who bettered his time, had taken off later than the hour laid down in the rules. Moisant, who had been delayed because he crashed his own machine and had to buy a

substitute mount from another pilot, claimed and was awarded the victory, becoming an American hero. The dispute sputtered on for years.

High flier

In 1910, the young Peruvian Jorge Chávez (who was born and lived in Paris) leapt to the forefront of European aviation with a series of record-breaking, high-altitude flights, eventually reaching 8,127ft (2,479m). In September, he boldly took up the challenge of flying across the Alps from Switzerland to Italy, for which feat a large cash prize was offered by the Aero-Club of Milan. Flying a Blériot XI, Chavez took off from the Swiss mountain town of Brig to cross the Simplon Pass, which rises at its summit to 6,600ft (2,013m). A cavalcade of cars carrying mechanics, doctors, and Alpine guides tracked him on the winding mountain road as he rose toward a beacon that had been lit at the top of

LET'S GO!

Jules Védrines raises his hand from the cockpit of his Deperdussin racer, signaling to his ground crew to release the aircraft for takeoff. The photograph was taken in Calais, France, during the Circuit-of-Europe, which took place between June 18 and July 7, 1911.

